

BOOK 1 OF THE HOLLOW DOMINION

# THE DREAMING GATE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1-3

3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

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# ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

## BACKGROUND

The players are drawn to the Hollow Dominion by a shared dream — a vision of a dying god calling for help. Upon arrival, they discover the kingdom is cursed by the death-throes of **Mordath, the Dreaming God**. The landscape warps unpredictably, nightmare creatures stalk the roads, and the populace is divided between those fighting to survive and those who've given in to madness.

The players discover they are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness, marked by a glowing sigil. They cannot leave until the curse is broken — and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him.

The adventure spans **three parts**: arrival at the Ashen Gate, investigation in the town of Drearym, and the climactic assault on the Gatehouse of Dreams.

## ADVENTURE DETAILS

|          |                      |
|----------|----------------------|
| System   | D&D 5e               |
| Levels   | 1-3                  |
| Sessions | 3-4                  |
| Players  | 3-5                  |
| Tone     | Dark fantasy mystery |

## FACTIONS

|              |                            |
|--------------|----------------------------|
| Waking Guard | Soldiers maintaining order |
| Dreamseekers | Cultists seeking freedom   |
| Veil Court   | Surviving nobility         |
| The Unbound  | Nightmare-consumed victims |

## ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

"For three nights running, you've had the same dream. A vast chamber of white stone, a figure on a throne robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. It speaks: 'Come. Please. Before it is too late.' On the fourth day, you each find a mark on your skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon."

# PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion

DANGER ●●○○○

## ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

The Ashen Gate is the only known entrance. Passing through is one-way. Characters who touch the purple energy must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or experience a brief vision of Mordath's throne room.



Eldon Voss — The Gatekeeper, former captain of the Waking Guard

## ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

"You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

- ◆ The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**
- ◆ The landscape warps unpredictably
- ◆ **Nightmare creatures** emerge at dusk
- ◆ The **Waking Guard** maintain order; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead
- ◆ "Don't sleep near running water — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."

### DM NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain. The curse broke his mind but fragments of wisdom remain. Treat him with kindness and he's a valuable source of information.

# THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

DANGER ●●●○○

## THE TWISTED ROAD

The road from the Ashen Gate to Drearym is called the **Twisted March** — a three-day journey through forest that has been warped by Mordath's dying dreams. Trees grow at impossible angles, their branches reaching toward a sky that shifts between twilight and starless night. Streams run purple with dream-energy, and the distance between landmarks changes depending on the time of day. The air itself feels thick and wrong, pressing against the skin like warm water. Sounds carry strangely — a whisper can echo for miles, while a shout is swallowed by the mist. The party's Dreambound sigils burn warmer as they travel deeper into the Dominion, a constant reminder that they are tethered to a dying god. Travel is slow: 12 miles per day instead of the normal 24, as the landscape itself seems to resist passage. Paths loop back on themselves, hills rise and fall like breathing things, and the stars above rearrange into patterns that hurt to look at.

## RANDOM EVENTS (ROLL D8 EACH DAY)

| D8 | EVENT                                                                                   |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | <b>Shifting Path:</b> DC 12 Survival or lose 1d4 hours + 1 exhaustion.                  |
| 2  | <b>Dream Echo:</b> One player sees Mordath before the curse. DC 13 WIS or 1 exhaustion. |
| 3  | <b>Nightmare Wolf:</b> Attacks from treeline. Flees at half HP.                         |
| 4  | <b>Traveler:</b> Refugee warns Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound.                |
| 5  | <b>Dream Shimmer:</b> "Find the three keys." DC 14 WIS or 2d6 psychic.                  |
| 6  | <b>Waking Guard Outpost:</b> Safe rest, rations, information.                           |
| 7  | <b>Thin Point:</b> Purple pool. DC 13 CON or pulled into dream vision.                  |
| 8  | <b>Peaceful Stretch:</b> Clean water, mushrooms. Recover 1 exhaustion.                  |

## NIGHT ENCOUNTERS (ROLL D6)

| D6  | ENCOUNTER                                                       |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1-2 | <b>Nightmare Wolves:</b> 1d4+1 attack the camp.                 |
| 3-4 | <b>Dream Whispers:</b> DC 12 WIS or no long rest, 1 exhaustion. |
| 5   | <b>Unbound Patrol:</b> 2 shamble past. Stealth DC 13.           |
| 6   | <b>Quiet Night:</b> Distant purple glow — the Gatehouse.        |



Nightmare Wolf — Shadow-wolf touched by dream-energy, emerges at dusk

*"The land remembers what it was. Sometimes, at the edges of your vision, you can see it — green fields, blue sky, children playing. Then you blink, and it's all twisted again."*



# MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map — Ashen Gate to Drearym



The Twisted March — Forest clearing with purple pools marking thin points between worlds.

## LANDMARKS

- ◆ **Ashen Gate (South):** Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss.
- ◆ **Waking Guard Outpost:** Day 1. Safe haven with supplies.
- ◆ **The Wellspring:** Day 1-2. Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel.
- ◆ **Ruined Tower of Valdris:** Day 2. DC 14 Investigation finds hidden journal page.
- ◆ **Purple Pools:** Thin points between worlds. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark.
- ◆ **Drearym (North):** Day 3. First major town. Faction tensions.

# PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

DANGER ●●●○○

## ARRIVAL

"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles. People eye your Dreambound marks with pity and suspicion."

The town is under martial law. The Waking Guard controls the gates and checks everyone entering. The party's Dreambound marks will be noted — some townsfolk will be hostile, others desperate for help.

## A — THE VIGOROUS DOG (INN)

A ramshackle two-story building with a painted sign of a running dog. The common room is warm but crowded with refugees. **Marta Greel** runs the place with a firm hand and a hand crossbow under the bar. Rooms are 5sp/night. She offers **50gp** for the safe return of her daughter **Lissa**, who went missing near the Wellspring three days ago. Marta is a former adventurer — she lost her left leg to a nightmare creature and walks with a peg leg. She's blunt, practical, and fiercely protective of the town.

## B — WAKING GUARD BARRACKS

A fortified stone building near the north gate, flying the Waking Guard's sun banner. **Captain Rena Ashford** commands 12 soldiers from here. She's stern but fair, and she's been holding the town together through sheer will for six months. She asks the party to investigate nightmare sightings on the eastern road (**30gp reward**). She warns them about Brother Caelum: "That priest is going to get people killed with his talk of killing the god." The barracks has a locked armory (DC 15 to pick) containing spare weapons and armor.

## C — OLD TOWN CHAPEL

Once a peaceful house of worship, now the meeting place of the **Dreamseekers**. The old holy symbols have been defaced and replaced with crescent moon sigils. **Brother Caelum** preaches to crowds of desperate Dreambound, telling them that killing Mordath will "free" them. He's charismatic and genuinely believes he's saving people — but he's being manipulated by The Architect, an entity within Mordath's dreams. The chapel has a secret basement with a ritual chamber where Caelum conducts his "sharing circles."

# DREARYM — KEY LOCATIONS

Town map and location details

## D — MARKET SQUARE

The central gathering place of Drearym. A weathered notice board holds missing persons flyers, bounty notices, and a Dreamseeker recruitment poster. Refugees have set up a camp in the eastern corner, trading information and supplies. A hooded figure (DC 14 Perception to notice) watches the party from the shadows — a Dreamseeker spy reporting to Brother Caelum.

## E — THE WELLSPRING

An ancient stone well outside the eastern wall, now leaking purple dream-energy. The water has turned violet and bubbles with otherworldly light. **Lissa Greel** was last seen here, sitting at the well's edge with eyes open but unseeing — trapped in a Dream Loop. The area is dangerous: nightmare creatures emerge from the well at night. Within 10ft of the well is difficult terrain (ground made soft by dream-energy). Within 5ft requires a DC 12 WIS save or be pulled toward the well.

## F — NORTH GATE

The main entrance to Drearym, controlled by the Waking Guard. Two guards check everyone entering and leaving. Curfew is enforced after sunset — anyone caught outside after dark is detained. The guards are sympathetic to Dreambound but follow Captain Ashford's orders without question. DC 12 Persuasion to pass without inspection.



Drearym — Letters mark key locations. Purple water flows through the settlement.

# NPCs OF THE DOMINION

*The god, the captain, the priest, and the innkeeper*



*Mordath — The Dreaming God, his divine form crumbling and leaking dream-energy into the mortal world*



*Captain Rena Ashford — Commander of the Waking Guard, holding Drearym together by sheer will*



*Brother Caelum — Dreamseeker priest, charismatic but being manipulated by The Architect*



*Marta Greel — Innkeeper of The Vigorous Dog, former adventurer, mother of missing Lissa*



# MARTA GREEL & THE DREAMING WELL

The innkeeper, the missing girl, and the nightmare spawn

## MARTA GREEL — INNKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), CHAOTIC GOOD

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 14  | 10  | 16  | 12  | 13  | 11  |
| +2  | +0  | +3  | +1  | +2  | +0  |

AC 12 | **HP** 27 (5d8+5) | **Speed** 20 ft. (peg leg)

**Skills:** Intimidation +2, Medicine +3, Survival +4

**Equipment:** Hand crossbow (+4, 1d6 piercing), peg leg (improvised weapon, +4, 1d4+2 bludgeoning)

## ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

**Option 1 — Physical Pull:** DC 14 STR. Nightmare Spawn attack. Failure = DC 13 WIS or stunned.

**Option 2 — Enter the Dream:** DC 13 WIS to enter. DC 13 Persuasion. Failure = 2d6 psychic.

**Option 3 — Disrupt:** DC 14 Arcana. Success = Spawn take 3d6 radiant. Failure = 2d6 psychic.



Nightmare Spawn — Shadow creatures touched by dream-energy, they drain the life force of the living

## NIGHTMARE SPAWN (RESKINNED SHADOW)

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

AC 12 | **HP** 16 (3d8+3) | **Speed** 40 ft.

**Resist:** Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, Thunder; B/P/S nonmagical

**Vuln:** Radiant (+1d6 from moonlight) | **Immune:** Exhaustion, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained

**Strength Drain.** +4 to hit, 2d6+2 **psychic** damage. STR reduced by 1d4. STR 0 = death, rises as Unbound in 1d4 rounds.

**Nightmare Aura:** Within 10ft, DC 11 WIS or frightened. **Amorphous, Shadow Stealth**

# PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

DANGER ●●●●○



The Gatehouse of Dreams — Ancient monastery built into the cliff, now consumed by dream-energy

## THE GATEHOUSE

The Gatehouse of Dreams is a fortress built into the face of a sheer cliff — the last outpost of the waking world before the boundary dissolves into Mordath's consciousness. Once a peaceful monastery dedicated to the Dreaming God, it has been consumed by the very energy it once worshipped. Purple dream-stuff seeps through cracks in the stone walls, pooling on floors that shift between solid rock and liquid starlight. The four wings of the complex are connected by a central courtyard where a fountain of purple liquid bubbles endlessly. The air here is thick with psychic residue — characters may hear fragments of Mordath's dreams as whispers, or catch glimpses of visions that haven't happened yet. Dreamsense is amplified within the Gatehouse: all Dreambound creatures within 60 feet are automatically detected. The deeper the party ventures, the thinner the veil becomes, until at the Dreaming Gate itself, the boundary between worlds is nothing more than a shimmer of purple light.

## THE FOUR WINGS

- ◆ **Dormitory (West):** DC 13 Investigation finds journal page: *"Mordath spoke to us in dreams. 'I have seen my death. The Architect stirs in my dreams.'"*
- ◆ **Library (North):** *"The Dreaming God: A Theological History"* — Mordath was a mortal who ascended through collective dreams. The Architect is his fear of death given sentience.
- ◆ **Chapel (East):** 3 Nightmare Spawn emerge from walls. DC 13 WIS or vision of Mordath pleading for help.
- ◆ **Gate Hall (South):** The Dreaming Gate — massive purple portal. Through it: Mordath's white throne room and the dying god himself.

## THE GATE HALL — APPROACHING THE PORTAL

*"The Gate Hall opens onto the cliff edge. Before you stands the Dreaming Gate — thirty feet tall, filled with swirling purple energy. Through the portal: a white throne room. On the throne sits a figure robed in starlight, mask of cracked porcelain. Dying."*

Between you and the portal stands a figure in purple armor, twin blades of crackling pink energy. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow — a weight that presses against your chest like deep water.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER ●●●●●



The Nightmare Knight — A Dreambound soul guarding the gate, wields twin energy blades of crackling pink lightning

THE GUARDIAN

The Nightmare Knight is a **Dreambound soul** — not evil, merely bound by duty. **Social:** DC 15 Persuasion (DC 12 if Lissa rescued). Success: "The god is dying. What you do in there will determine whether the Dominion lives or dies." **Combat:** Hard for level 3. Surrenders at 20 HP: "Perhaps you are what he has been waiting for."

NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

MEDIUM UNDEAD, LAWFUL NEUTRAL

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 18  | 14  | 18  | 12  | 14  | 16  |
| +4  | +2  | +4  | +1  | +2  | +3  |

AC 15 | HP 85 (10d8+40) | Speed 30 ft.

**Resist:** Necrotic, B/P/S nonmagical | **Vuln:** Radiant | **Immune:** Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned

**Multiattack.** Two Energy Blades. *Energy Blade.* +7, 2d6+4 slashing + 1d8 psychic.

*Life Drain (Recharge 5-6).* +7, 3d6+4 psychic, heals half. *Dream Step (Bonus).* Teleport 30ft.

*Parry (Reaction).* +3 AC vs one melee. **Legendary (1/round):** *Reposition.* Move 15ft.

TOUCHING THE GATE

"The world dissolves into white. Three keys. Find them. The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths. Please. I cannot hold on much longer."

Each character gains **Dreamsense** (30ft, always active) and visions of Books 2-5 locations.

# END OF BOOK 1

Return to Drearym — and a cliffhanger for Book 2

## RESOLUTION

- ◆ Mordath is dying — not trying to harm anyone.
- ◆ There are **three keys**: The Architect, The Crown, The Heart.
- ◆ The Architect — a fragment of Mordath's own fear — wants the god dead.
- ◆ Brother Caelum and the Dreamseekers are being manipulated.
- ◆ The players are Dreambound — tied to Mordath's fate.

## CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2

"As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum, eyes glowing purple. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force."

## TREASURE & REWARDS

- Guardian's Longsword (*uncommon, attunement*)**  
+1 longsword. Extra 1d4 psychic vs undead/fiends. 1/day: *detect thoughts* (DC 13).
- Marta's Gratitude**  
If Lissa rescued: *Potion of Greater Healing* + *Cloak of Elvenkind*. Free lodging.
- Monastery Journal**  
25gp value. DC 15 History reveals Fractured Court location (Book 2).

**Milestone:** Party reaches level 3.

## GM NOTES

- Tone:** Waking up in someone else's nightmare. Mordath is not a villain — he's a dying god.
- Scaling:** Level 1: Knight HP 60, no Legendary Actions. Level 4+: +2 Nightmare Spawn, Knight +10 HP.

## THE HOLLOW DOMINION

A once-prosperous kingdom cursed by the death-throes of Mordath, the Dreaming God. His nightmares leak into the waking world — twisting landscapes, corrupting creatures, and driving the populace mad.

The players are Dreambound — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness. They cannot leave until the curse is broken. But if Mordath dies, they die with him.

From the Ashen Gate to the Gatehouse of Dreams, the party must navigate nightmare-ravaged lands, choose which faction to trust, and find the three keys that can save the Dominion — or doom it forever.

D&D 5e | Levels 1-3 | 3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

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